

From Teacher to Leader: Watertown School Principal Shares 25-Year Education Journey

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Watertown, New York — Imagine spending a quarter-century finding and unlocking the potential within the minds of future generations. That is the special kind of impact Chad Fairchild makes as a principal in the Watertown City School District. Fast forward 25 years, and that same passion for education is still burning bright.

His journey, however, did not begin in a classroom; rather, it started with a dream of becoming a missionary overseas.

Fairchild, 52, began his higher education path by studying Spanish and French. However, after meeting his wife Susy—who was originally from Mexico—in the late 1980s, the couple moved to Guatemala where Fairchild taught English to business executives and also attended a Bible college.

“Most of it was great conversations with fascinating people,” Fairchild said, “and I got to pick their brains on all kinds of things and learn from them.”

When Fairchild and his wife returned to New York State in the 1990s, he took his stepfather’s advice and became a foreign

language teacher at Watertown High School, given his extensive knowledge of both French and Spanish.

Fairchild went on to teach those subjects full-time for nine years before taking on a new role as the district's technology integration specialist. In this hybrid job, he worked to incorporate new technologies into classrooms while still teaching half-time.

“I knew at some point... I’m going to want a new challenge,” Fairchild said. “I don’t foresee myself being in a classroom in 25... 30 years. I’m going to want something different to sink my teeth into; and I really loved technology a lot, so I became very involved with that.”

The experience of being both an educator and administrator served Fairchild well when he later became a school principal. Over the past 15 years, he has led four different schools—Knickerbocker Elementary, Starbuck Elementary, Watertown High, and most recently H.T. Wiley Intermediate.

According to Fairchild, he sees value in experiencing different grade levels and understanding students' development across ages. He also explained how working with a wide demographic gave him a “very different perspective of the whole student and the family setting.”

Now as Wiley’s principal, Fairchild continues to prioritize a welcoming environment where students feel respected and capable of learning. His approach to education has left positive impacts on both students and parents alike.

“My son has always been quite sensitive,” said Pamela Barrett—a parent of a student who had Fairchild as a principal at Knickerbocker Elementary. “There were many times when he would get super overwhelmed, and Mr. Fairchild would let him stay in his office and call me on the phone. It really speaks volumes about how much he cares about his students and what kind of environment he wants to create for them.”

Looking ahead, Fairchild plans to have a lasting effect with his educational philosophy, going beyond creating a welcoming environment for his students.

“Every kid has gifts, abilities, talents,” Fairchild said, “and our goal is to help them to read and write, but also help them as a whole student—how to develop all of the other areas that they are gifted in and are interested in.”

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Website Sources:

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- <https://www.wwnytv.com/2023/07/05/watertown-school-district-names-three-new-assignments/>
- <https://wiley.watertowncsd.org/about-us>

Interview Subjects:

- *Chad Fairchild, Principal of H.T. Wiley Intermediate School*
- *Pamela Barrett, Parent of Watertown City School District Student*